

See also: Vattel's *The Law of Nations* 108 ■ The Hague Conventions 174–177 ■ The Treaty of Versailles 192–193
 ■ The Universal Declaration of Human Rights 222–229 ■ The International Criminal Court 298–303



President Roosevelt talks with Prime Minister Churchill after they had signed the Atlantic Charter aboard the USS *Augusta* in the Atlantic Ocean on August 14, 1941.

standards for what was acceptable in war, what was not, and what constituted a war crime. The ideas that the Conventions embody emerged originally from the Civil War, when in 1863 President Abraham Lincoln issued the Lieber Code, laying out rules for the protection of civilians in wartime, as well as what constituted a truce, how spies and dissenters should be treated, and more.

The UN's roots

One of the key aims of the Hague Conventions was a system for settling disputes between nations. The 1899 conference saw the creation of the Permanent Court of Arbitration, which began work in 1902 to resolve differences on issues such as boundaries, sovereignty, and human rights. The court sat in the specially built Peace Palace in The Hague, which now houses the International Criminal Court.

The Hague Conventions were soon disrupted when Germany broke the rules with its invasion

of Belgium in 1914. World War I saw many more violations, including the widespread use of poison gas.

The League of Nations

When the mayhem of World War I was over, some of the victorious Allies came together in Paris in 1919 determined that such a war should never happen again—that this should be “the war to end all wars.” The Paris Peace Conference established the League of Nations with the avowed aim “to promote international cooperation and to achieve peace and security.” The idea was to solve disputes between countries before they erupted into open warfare.

World War I marked the end of the age of empire. Instead, the victors wanted to build a world of independent nations coming together in open forums rather than through secret deals made behind closed doors, as had been the case in the 19th century. In this way, the victors hoped they could de-escalate tensions and disarm.

In the event, crucially, the United States, which was still wedded to its isolationist ideal, decided not to involve itself, and the League therefore had no power to enforce its will. As British prime minister David Lloyd George put it, “It had weak links spreading everywhere and no grip anywhere.” When Nazi Germany built up its military and invaded Austria, Czechoslovakia, and Poland, the League of Nations was unable to stop Germany’s actions, triggering another world war. Yet even as the League collapsed, Allied leaders were beginning to think of a new organization that might prevent a third conflagration.

In August 1941, with the German–Italian Axis seemingly growing in power, US president Franklin D. Roosevelt and UK prime minister Winston Churchill met to frame what came to be called the Atlantic Charter, an affirmation “of certain common principles in the »

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A world government must be created which is able to solve conflicts between nations by judicial decision.

Albert Einstein

Toward World Government, 1948

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